

Rotary-Wing Diversity

By the 1960s, visions of inexpensive commuter helicopters and scheduled services between city centers had faded as efforts to reduce mechanical complexity were defeated and costs remained stubbornly high. The realization took hold that helicopters would always be specialized machines fit only for tasks no other vehicle could do. The Vietnam War led to the rapid development of helicopters as troop transports, gunships, and rescue aircraft, while offshore oil exploration boosted the civil helicopter industry.



△ Bell UH-1B Iroquois ("Huey") 1960

Origin US
Engine 960 shp Lycoming YT53-L-5 turboshaft
Top speed 135 mph (217 km/h)

This is US Army's first turbine helicopter—a prototype flew in 1956. The UH-1B is still in service, larger, heavier, and twice as powerful as the early version; more than 16,000 were built.



△ Bell AH-1 Cobra 1965

Origin US
Engine 1,400 shp Lycoming T53-13 turboshaft
Top speed 196 mph (315 km/h)

Developed for the Vietnam War using the dynamic components of the Huey allied to a narrow, hard-to-hit fuselage, the agile, heavily armored Cobra was the first dedicated helicopter gunship.



△ Westland Scout AH Mk1 1960

Origin UK
Engine 1,050 shp Rolls-Royce Nimbus 105 turboshaft (derated to 710 hp)
Top speed 131 mph (211 km/h)

Rugged and robust, the Scout served the British Army in every conflict from Aden to the Falklands, although early Nimbus engines had to be changed after only four to six hours.

▽ Westland Wessex HAS3 1964

Origin UK
Engine 1,600 shp Napier Gazelle 18 Mk165 turboshaft
Top speed 127 mph (204 km/h)

An upgraded antisubmarine version of the original Wessex Mk1, the HAS3 carried a revolutionary Type 195 sonar system that was more expensive than the helicopter itself.



△ Wallis WA-116 Agile 1961

Origin UK
Engine 72 hp McCulloch 4318A
Top speed 120 mph (193 km/h)

Named after music hall star Nellie Wallace, "Little Nellie" appeared in the James Bond movie *You Only Live Twice*, flown by its maker, the late Ken Wallis, who set 30 world autogyro records.

